

The Unwilled Replica: Two Parallels for the Persistence of Female State Allegory

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Abstract

This article asks why the female allegorical body of the modern state — Marianne, Britannia, Germania, Columbia, A República — persists across a century of institutional reproduction with such structural fidelity. The author's doctoral thesis, *Iconocracia*, already accounts for this persistence through an original conceptual apparatus: the *Contrato Sexual Visual*, *Feminilidade de Estado*, and the process of *ENDURECIMENTO* across three iconocratic regimes (FUNDACIONAL, NORMATIVO, MILITAR). What remains underspecified is the *kind of agency* operating when a symbolic form survives largely unchanged. This article proposes two heuristic parallels — not governing theories — drawn from outside art history and legal historiography: Richard Dawkins's account of the meme as a self-propagating unit of cultural imitation, and Hannah Arendt's account of banal, unreflective bureaucratic participation in systemic harm. Both parallels are used strictly as interpretive aids that illuminate a mechanism of reproduction requiring neither conscious design nor active belief. Neither is imported as doctrine, and both are subjected to their own internal critiques (Dan Sperber's objection to memetics; Bettina Stangneth's historiographical challenge to Arendt's empirical account of Adolf Eichmann) before being folded back into the thesis's own apparatus.

1. Introduction

The central puzzle this article addresses is not *why* the modern state produced a female allegorical body — the author's thesis already answers this through the concept of the *Contrato Sexual Visual* (the author's own formulation; not to be attributed to Carole Pateman's *sexual contract*) — but *how* that body continued to replicate, largely unchanged in its structural logic, across national borders and successive political regimes, long after the specific historical actors who first commissioned it had died or lost power.

Two bodies of theory outside the discipline offer a productive, if partial, parallel for this problem of unattended persistence: evolutionary theory's account of the replicator, and political theory's account of unreflective

participation in systemic harm. This article treats both as heuristic devices. Neither displaces the thesis's own apparatus; both are introduced, tested against their internal critics, and then set aside in favour of the author's original framework, which remains the article's explanatory core.

2. The established apparatus

Three concepts anchor the argument and are retained here without alteration:

- ***Contrato Sexual Visual*** — the author's term for the instrumentalisation of the female body by the state for purposes of legal-political legitimation. This is an original formulation of the thesis, independent of prior sexual-contract theory in political philosophy.
- ***Feminilidade de Estado*** — femininity as a technology of visual governance, again an original formulation of the thesis, independent of Marie-José Mondzain's iconic economy.
- ***ENDURECIMENTO*** — the progressive hardening of the allegorical body, measured across ten ordinal indicators (disembodiment, postural rigidity, desexualisation, facial uniformisation, heraldicisation, architectural framing, narrative erasure, monochromatisation, seriality, state inscription), moving through three regimes: FUNDACIONAL (foundational, dynamic, exposed), NORMATIVO (bureaucratic, domesticated, serial), and MILITAR (imperial-military, armoured, rigid).

The thesis's existing diachronic method already draws on Aby Warburg's *Pathosformel* (the gestural-affective formula that survives and returns) and *Nachleben* (the afterlife of antique form), as developed in the *Bilderatlas Mnemosyne* (WARBURG, 2000). This gives the corpus a vocabulary for formal survival-with-mutation. What Warburg's vocabulary does not supply is an explicit account of *why* a given variant, rather than its competitors, is the one that survives at each institutional juncture. It is this gap that the two parallels below attempt to address, provisionally.

3. First parallel: the meme as an unwilling replicator

In the closing chapter of *The Selfish Gene*, Richard Dawkins introduces the meme as a cultural analogue to the gene: "Examples of memes are tunes, ideas, catch-phrases, clothes fashions, ways of making pots or of building arches. Just as genes propagate themselves in the gene pool by leaping from body to body via sperms or eggs, so memes propagate themselves in the meme pool by leaping from brain to brain" (DAWKINS, 1976, cap. 11). The organism, in this account, is not the beneficiary of genetic replication but its "survival machine" — a vehicle, not a purpose.

Susan Blackmore later formalised the criteria of successful replication inherited from Dawkins — fidelity, fecundity, and longevity — and introduced the *memeplex*, a set of co-adapted memes that replicate together because they mutually reinforce one another's survival (BLACKMORE, 1999).

Where the parallel illuminates. Read against the thesis's own apparatus, the allegorical *Pathosformel* functions structurally like a meme: it “leaps” across borders (Marianne into Germania, Britannia, Columbia, and eventually the Brazilian *República*), it mutates under variation, and it is retained or discarded according to how well it fits the institutional context it enters. The *memeplex* offers a name for what the thesis already treats informally as a “package”: the coordinated bundle of attributes — scales, blindfold, classical drapery — that defines a *NORMATIVO Justitia* and that replicates as a unit rather than attribute by attribute. Read this way, the ten *ENDURECIMENTO* indicators correspond loosely to replication criteria: seriality to fecundity, monochromatisation and heraldicisation to fidelity (reduction of permissible variation), and state inscription to longevity (institutional anchoring against loss).

Where the parallel is limited. Dan Sperber has objected that memetics treats cultural transmission as high-fidelity copying analogous to genetic replication, when in fact cultural transmission is closer to *reconstruction* guided by cognitive “attraction” than to literal copying: representations are re-derived, not duplicated, at each transmission event (SPERBER, 2000). This objection matters here because it blocks an over-literal reading of the parallel: the allegorical body is not passed from mint to mint as an identical template; it is re-derived by each engraver, each committee, each printer, under locally specific constraints. The meme parallel, properly bounded by Sperber's objection, licenses only a loose structural analogy — persistence-with-variation across a population of copyists — not a claim that cultural and genetic replication share a single mechanism.

4. Second parallel: banal, unreflective reproduction

Hannah Arendt's report on the trial of Adolf Eichmann offers a second parallel, addressed here to a different feature of the puzzle: not *how* a form travels, but *why* it can be reproduced by many individual actors, over a century, without any one of them individually authoring or even endorsing its political content.

Arendt described Eichmann as “neither perverted nor sadistic” but “terrifyingly normal” (ARENDR, 1963 *apud* WHITE, 2024), a bureaucrat whose evil deeds were connected, in her account, to “thoughtlessness” — an “inability... to think from the standpoint of somebody else” that meant he “never realised what he was doing” (ARENDR, 1963 *apud* WHITE, 2024). The disturbing implication of her thesis was not that Eichmann was

innocent, but that systemic harm on the largest scale could be executed by ordinary functionaries discharging procedure, without requiring a correspondingly monstrous intention.

Where the parallel illuminates. Applied — strictly as a structural analogy, and at an entirely different order of moral gravity — to the reproduction of state allegory, this account supplies a third position between two poles the author had initially, and too simply, opposed: the blind replicator that “cares” about nothing (Dawkins’s meme) and the deliberate architect of a gendered visual order (an over-intentional reading of the *Contratto Sexual Visual*). Arendt’s account names a middle mechanism: distributed, procedural, non-deliberate reproduction by administrators — a mint engraver selecting the “already approved” design, a legislative committee ratifying a submitted model, a textbook editor reusing the plate on file — none of whom need to hold, still less to have devised, the political theory that the allegory enacts. This mechanism explains persistence without requiring either a puppet-master or an indifferent cosmic filter, and it distributes responsibility across an institutional chain rather than concentrating it in a single intending author.

Two necessary cautions. First, the disproportion of registers must be stated without qualification: Arendt wrote about the administrative logistics of mass extermination; this article concerns the conventions of coinage, seals, and monumental sculpture. No equivalence of severity is claimed or implied. What is borrowed is the *structural mechanism* — reproduction sustained by the absence of reflection, not by its presence — not the scale of harm.

Second, the empirical basis of Arendt’s specific account of Eichmann has been seriously challenged. Bettina Stangneth, drawing on the “Argentina Papers” and the Sassen interviews, presents an Eichmann who was ideologically committed and, in his own words, a “fanatical [Nazi] warrior” beneath the “cautious bureaucrat” (STANGNETH, 2014 *apud* WHITE, 2024) — far from the thoughtless figure Arendt described. This article therefore treats “banal, unreflective reproduction” as a general conceptual mechanism available independently of the disputed empirical claims about the case that occasioned it, following the same caution the discipline already applies when extending Warburg’s *Nachleben* — coined for the survival of pagan antiquity in the Renaissance — to nineteenth- and twentieth-century political iconography: the concept is portable; the case study that produced it is not.

5. Synthesis: three regimes, three modes of agency

Read together, the two parallels suggest that the thesis’s three iconocratic regimes can be redescribed, provisionally, as three distinct modes of agency, not merely three visual profiles:

Regime	Dominant mode of agency	Mechanism	Relation to the parallels
FUNDACIONAL	Deliberate ideological commissioning	A revolutionary or founding authority explicitly commissions the image; an author and a brief are identifiable	Neither parallel applies cleanly here — this is the register of intentional design the <i>Contrato Sexual Visual</i> already names directly
NORMATIVO	Banal administrative reproduction	The image recurs because it is “already approved”; no individual actor deliberates on its political content	Arendt’s parallel applies most directly; the meme parallel applies to the <i>form</i> that gets reproduced
MILITAR	Mixed	Either explicit propaganda (a commissioned war poster) or logistical reuse of an already-approved template (a colonial coin, a war medal)	Both parallels apply, depending on the specific object

On this reading, *ENDURECIMENTO* is not the outcome of a collective agent’s intention to purify the allegorical body. It is the emergent, statistically expected outcome of successive banal reproductions, each of which defaults to the safest, most generic, most easily re-approved variant — precisely the tendency the ten indicators measure (disembodiment, facial uniformisation, monochromatisation). No one needs to want the purification. The administrative default produces it.

6. Limitations

Both parallels are heuristic devices, introduced and bounded deliberately. The article does not claim that cultural transmission is a species of biological replication, nor that the reproduction of state allegory is equivalent in gravity to bureaucratic participation in genocide. Both claims would misstate what has been argued. The parallels are retained only insofar as they clarify a mechanism — reproduction without either blind indifference or conscious design — that the thesis’s own apparatus

(*Contrato Sexual Visual, Feminilidade de Estado, ENDURECIMENTO*) remains the primary and sufficient framework for explaining. Readers who find either parallel unpersuasive should still find the three-regime redescription of agency (§5) available on the thesis's own terms, independent of Dawkins or Arendt.

7. Conclusion

The female allegorical body of the modern state persists not because a single author wills its persistence, nor because it is a self-interested replicator indifferent to consequence, but because most of its reproduction is banal: routine, procedural, and unreflective. Two parallels borrowed cautiously from outside the discipline — Dawkins's meme and Arendt's account of thoughtless bureaucratic participation — help name this mechanism without displacing the thesis's own explanatory apparatus, which continues to carry the argument's political weight.

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A note on sourcing: the Arendt and Stangneth quotations above are cited apud White (2024) because the primary editions were not directly consulted for page-level verification in this draft; the Contrato Sexual Visual, Feminilidade de Estado, and ENDURECIMENTO framework is presented as the author's own interpretive apparatus, not attributed to any external source. Not all bibliographic details (specific page numbers for the Dawkins, Arendt, and Blackmore citations) were available in the sources consulted for this draft; where precise pagination could not be confirmed, the citation is given by chapter or general work only.